

The Invisible Ledger: Quantifying ASEAN's \$170 Billion Unmeasured Platform Economy

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Abstract

This paper estimates the scale of platform-mediated transaction value that remains outside routine third-party income reporting across ASEAN's five largest digital markets. Using directly reported and transparently derived figures for Grab, GoTo, and Sea Limited/Shopee, I estimate a \$66.8 billion wedge for Indonesia and a calibrated ASEAN-5 total of \$170 billion. The corresponding ecosystem ratio is 16.0:1: for each dollar booked as platform revenue, approximately \$16 is paid onward or otherwise attributed to ecosystem participants. This ratio is an accounting measure of gross transaction value not booked as platform revenue; it is not a measure of participant profit, tax liability, or value-added. The Indonesia estimate is anchored most directly by GoTo, for which both gross transaction value and net revenue are reported in Indonesia-native filings. Grab and Shopee require disclosed take rates or independently sourced market-share information, and the four non-Indonesian country estimates apply Indonesia's blended 5.88 percent retained share to country transaction volumes. They are calibrated rescalings rather than independent measurements. As a limited policy check, Malaysia's 2024 low-value-goods expansion collected \$114 million directly. A descriptive two-country before-and-after difference against Vietnam gives \$152 million, or \$149 million using period-average exchange rates. The comparison has four annual observations, unmatched tax bases, and no pre-trend test, so it is reported as a bound rather than a causal estimate. GoTo's own filings show the share of transaction value not booked as revenue rising from 95.7 percent in 2020 to 97.6 percent in 2023. The policy implication is narrower than a call for immediate taxation: digital platforms already hold the records required for third-party reporting, but registration, reporting, and withholding should be designed separately and evaluated against administrative costs and participant welfare.

Keywords: digital economy; platform economy; fiscal capacity; informal sector; third-party reporting; ASEAN; tax administration.

JEL codes: H25; H26; O17; O33; F23.

1. Introduction

Southeast Asia's digital economy grew from \$98 billion in 2020 to \$263 billion in 2024 (Google, Temasek and Bain 2024). Yet platform scale and tax-administrative visibility are not the same thing. A platform records the transaction, computes the payout, and books its own revenue, while the participant's gross receipts may remain outside routine third-party income reporting. This paper estimates that administrative gap for the largest platform markets in ASEAN.

The headline result is a \$170 billion calibrated "invisible wedge" across Indonesia, Vietnam, the Philippines, Thailand, and Malaysia. The term invisible refers to the administration's information channel, not to criminal concealment. The transactions are digitally recorded, but the record is generally used for payment and platform accounting rather than transmitted as an income report for the participant. The regional figure is an order-of-magnitude estimate anchored on Indonesia; it is not five independent country measurements.

A schematic example clarifies the accounting. Suppose a platform processes 100 units of transaction value and books 10 as revenue. The remaining 90 is visible in the platform's transaction system but is not platform revenue. It may include merchant receipts, driver payouts, inventory costs, taxes already paid elsewhere, and other pass-through values. The paper therefore measures gross participant-facing transaction value, not

participant profit or unpaid tax. The empirical question is whether that recorded but separately unreported flow is large enough to matter for tax administration.

1.1 Contributions

First, I provide directly reported and transparently derived platform-level estimates for Indonesia, then use the measured Indonesian retained share to calibrate four additional ASEAN markets. Only GoTo reports both relevant inputs independently; every derived input is labelled by provenance.

Second, I compare the regional estimate with Malaysia’s January 2024 low-value-goods expansion. I report the policy’s own collections and a descriptive two-country before-and-after difference against Vietnam, without a significance claim and without treating unmatched tax bases as a valid causal control.

Third, I document fiscal decoupling in GoTo’s Indonesia-native filings: gross transaction value remains high while the share booked as net revenue falls. This is the result least dependent on cross-platform or cross-country calibration.

1.2 What this paper does and does not claim

Table 1 states the inferential boundaries before the estimates are presented. The correction history is retained in Appendix A so that provenance is auditable without turning the main argument into an errata list.

Table 1. Claims and non-claims

Established here	Not established here
An order-of-magnitude regional estimate built from one measured market and four calibrated rescalings.	Five independent country measurements or a complete measure of ASEAN’s informal economy.
A descriptive \$114–152 million range around Malaysia’s 2024 expansion, stable to the FX convention used.	A causal effect identified by matched tax bases, parallel trends, or a statistically informative panel.
A directly grounded GoTo time series in which the unbooked share of GTV rises from 95.7% to 97.6%.	That all participant-facing GTV is profit, taxable income, unpaid tax, or GDP value-added.

2. Literature review and theoretical framework

2.1 Platform economics and the location of value

The economics of multisided platforms begins with the interaction of distinct user groups whose participation affects the value received by the other side. Rochet and Tirole (2003), Caillaud and Jullien (2003), Parker and Van Alstyne (2005), and Armstrong (2006) show why platform pricing cannot be read as a simple markup over cost: prices and commissions are chosen to balance cross-group network effects, participation, and competition. Hagiu and Wright (2015) further distinguish a multisided platform from a vertically integrated firm by locating decision rights and entrepreneurial effort with affiliated participants rather than inside the platform. Evans and Schmalensee (2016) translate the same point into the business-model literature. These results explain why low retained shares can coexist with large ecosystems and why platform revenue is a poor proxy for the transaction value coordinated through the platform.

2.2 Informality, platform work, and measurement

Traditional informal-economy estimates rely on household surveys, firm surveys, or indirect macroeconomic indicators. Medina and Schneider (2019) estimate a large global shadow economy; La Porta and Shleifer (2014) emphasise the small scale and low productivity of informal firms; and Ulyssea (2018) shows that registration and off-the-books employment are distinct margins whose welfare effects cannot be inferred from formal status alone. The International Labour Organization (2021, 2023) likewise treats platform work and informality as overlapping but non-identical categories.

Platform participants occupy an unusual position in this literature. Their transactions are priced, recorded, and settled through a formal intermediary, but the participant may remain self-employed, unregistered, below filing thresholds, or simply outside an automatic reporting channel. The object measured here is therefore not the shadow economy as conventionally defined. It is a digitally recorded flow whose administrative treatment resembles self-reported income even though an intermediary already possesses the record.

2.3 Third-party reporting as tax capacity

A central result in public finance is that tax compliance depends strongly on third-party information and remittance structure. Kleven et al. (2011) find an evasion rate of 0.3 percent on income subject to third-party reporting versus 37 percent on self-reported income in Denmark. Pomeranz (2015) shows that the VAT paper trail creates self-enforcement across firms, while Naritomi (2019) demonstrates that consumer-held records can raise reported sales. Kleven, Kreiner and Saez (2016) formalise firms as fiscal intermediaries, and Slemrod (2019) places information reporting and remittance regimes among the core instruments of modern enforcement.

Jensen (2022) connects this mechanism to development: as employment moves into organisations that keep records and report income, the feasible tax base expands. Platform work creates a new configuration - a large intermediary with detailed records but, in many jurisdictions, no comprehensive obligation to report seller or worker income. Collins et al. (2019) and Garin et al. (2023) show how platform information returns affect the measured prevalence of gig work in the United States. The administrative problem is therefore not a lack of data generation; it is the absence, incompleteness, or fragmentation of the reporting rule.

2.4 Digital taxation and platform-reporting rules

Corporate digital-tax reforms and platform-participant reporting address different bases. The OECD Pillar One blueprint concerns the allocation of taxing rights over large multinational enterprises (OECD 2020b). By contrast, the OECD's Forum on Tax Administration report and Model Rules require platforms to collect and report information on income realised by sellers and service providers (OECD 2019, 2020a). The European Union's DAC7 regime similarly imposes due-diligence and reporting duties on platform operators (European Union 2021). These instruments provide the closest policy precedent for the mechanism studied here: using the platform's existing transaction record to improve participant-level visibility without treating platform revenue as the participant tax base.

3. Theoretical framework: the ecosystem ratio

$$\text{Ecosystem ratio} = (\text{GTV} - \text{platform revenue}) / \text{platform revenue} \quad (1)$$

The numerator is gross transaction value not booked as platform revenue. The denominator is the platform revenue already visible in corporate accounts. The ratio therefore describes the scale of participant-facing transaction value relative to the platform's auditable revenue base. It does not, by itself, establish participant profit, taxable income, value-added, non-compliance, or tax due.

This distinction is essential. Platform filings and investor disclosures can make the accounting gap measurable, but the tax treatment of the residual depends on participant type, deductible costs, thresholds, registration status, and taxes already remitted through other channels. The empirical contribution is to quantify the size of the recorded flow that current corporate-level digital taxes do not directly reach.

4. Data, methodology, and provenance

4.1 Source provenance by platform

Table 2. Source provenance for each Indonesia platform figure

Platform	Metric	Source	Provenance
Grab	Revenue	Grab 2023 Form 20-F	Directly disclosed at country level.
Grab	GTV	Derived	Indonesia revenue divided by company-wide take rate (11.24%); country GTV is not independently disclosed.
GoTo	GTV and revenue	GoTo 2023 annual report	Both inputs directly reported by an Indonesia-native company.
Shopee	GTV and revenue	Sea 2023 Form 20-F; Momentum Works 2024	Regional revenue/GMV disclosed; Indonesia GMV estimated from market share, with revenue derived from disclosed take rate (10.06%).

Only GoTo supplies both inputs independently. Grab and Shopee ratios inherit the take-rate assumptions used to derive one or both components.

4.2 Indonesia platform estimates

GoTo's markedly higher ecosystem ratio (40.0×) relative to Grab and Shopee (roughly 8–9×) reflects its consolidated GTV reporting: Tokopedia's full marketplace GMV is included while GoTo books only a thin commission as revenue. The spread across platforms is therefore an artifact of reporting convention, not a measured difference in the share of GTV not booked as platform revenue, and it should not be read as evidence that the ratio is a stable structural parameter. The corrected Indonesia blended take rate - total platform revenue divided by total platform GTV - is 5.88%, used as the calibration basis for the four remaining ASEAN countries in Section 7.

Table 3. Indonesia's invisible wedge, 2023

Platform	Indonesia GTV	Net revenue	Unbooked GTV	Ecosystem ratio
Grab	\$5.40B	\$0.61B	\$4.80B	7.9×
GoTo	\$39.80B	\$0.97B	\$38.83B	40.0×
Shopee	\$25.80B	\$2.60B	\$23.20B	8.9×
Total	\$71.00B	\$4.18B	\$66.83B	16.0×

Wedges and ratios are calculated from unrounded source values. Displayed components are rounded and may therefore not reproduce the reported results exactly.

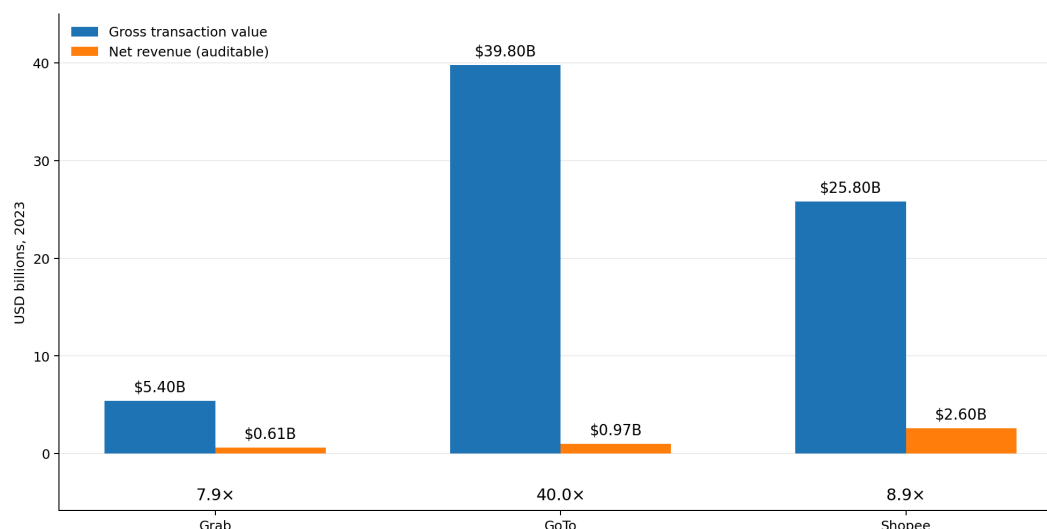


Figure 1. Indonesia platform gross transaction value and net revenue, 2023. Ratios describe the relation between the paired bars and are strongly affected by reporting convention.

4.3 Sensitivity of the Indonesia estimate

Because the blended take rate is the only free parameter in the Indonesia calculation, it is worth showing what the estimate does when that parameter moves. Table 4 varies it across the plausible range.

Table 4. Sensitivity to the take-rate assumption

Take rate	Platform revenue	Unbooked GTV	Ecosystem ratio
5.00% (low)	\$3.55B	\$67.45B	19.0×
5.88% (base)	\$4.18B	\$66.83B	16.0×
7.50% (earlier draft)	\$5.33B	\$65.68B	12.3×
10.00% (high)	\$7.10B	\$63.90B	9.0×

The dollar wedge is comparatively insensitive to the take rate because the retained share is small; the ratio is largely a transformation of that assumed share.

5. GoTo results: fiscal decoupling

This section is unaffected by the corrections in Appendix A, since GoTo's figures are Indonesia-native, directly reported, and expressed as shares rather than ratios.

Table 5. GoTo's fiscal decoupling over time

Year	GTV	Net revenue	Unbooked GTV	Share unbooked
2020	\$28.0B	\$1.20B	\$26.8B	95.7%
2021	\$35.0B	\$1.40B	\$33.6B	96.0%
2022	\$39.0B	\$1.20B	\$37.8B	96.9%
2023	\$39.8B	\$0.97B	\$38.8B	97.6%

The invisible share increased from 95.7% to 97.6%. This is the most directly grounded result in the paper: both inputs are reported by an Indonesia-domiciled company in its own filings, and the measure is a share of a single company's disclosed figures rather than a cross-platform extrapolation.

6. Malaysia's 2024 base expansion

Malaysia extended its digital tax base in January 2024 through the Low Value Goods (LVG) regime (Royal Malaysian Customs Department 2023; Ministry of Finance, Malaysia 2023). Two independent readings of what that expansion captured are available, and this draft reports both rather than resolving them into one number.

The direct reading is the policy’s own reported collections. Malaysia’s LVG regime collected \$114 million in its first year, reported separately from the pre-existing SToDS stream in parliamentary reporting. This is an observed figure, not an estimate.

The comparative reading is a descriptive two-country before-and-after comparison with Vietnam’s foreign-portal VAT and corporate income tax collections — collections by non-resident digital suppliers registered through the tax authority’s foreign-supplier portal (VietnamPlus 2025), a series distinct from domestic e-commerce VAT and one whose own base did not change over the period. Computed directly from official annual totals: Malaysia moved from \$275 million in 2023 to \$503 million in 2024 (SToDS \$389M plus LVG \$114M), a change of \$228 million. Vietnam moved from \$300 million to \$376 million, a change of \$76 million. The difference between the two changes is \$152 million.

These annual totals are converted at exchange rates close to current levels rather than at 2023–2024 period averages; the underlying figures are not sensitive to this choice. Recomputed at verified period-average rates (USD/MYR 4.561 in 2023 and 4.576 in 2024; USD/VND 23,836 in 2023 and 25,056 in 2024), Malaysia’s change is \$205.9 million and Vietnam’s is \$56.9 million, giving a difference between the two changes of \$149.0 million — within 2% of the \$152 million figure above.

Table 6. Base-expansion capture, two descriptive readings

Series	2023	2024	Change
Malaysia (SToDS + LVG)	\$275M	\$503M	+\$228M
Vietnam (foreign portal VAT + CIT)	\$300M	\$376M	+\$76M
Difference between changes	—	—	\$152M
Malaysia LVG, directly reported	—	\$114M	—

At period-average exchange rates, the difference between changes is \$149.0 million.

The two readings bracket a range of \$114–152 million. The comparative difference is higher because it attributes to the expansion some of the growth in the pre-existing SToDS stream, which grew faster in 2024 (\$275M to \$389M) than Vietnam’s comparison series; whether that acceleration is attributable to the base expansion or to independent growth in the existing base cannot be resolved with these data.

On inference. An earlier draft reported this estimate as \$124 million with a standard error of \$8.8 million and $p < .001$, derived from a quarterly panel reconstructed by linear interpolation between annual totals. That procedure is not sound for inference. Linear interpolation produces a series whose residuals are small by construction, so the resulting standard error reflects the smoothness of the interpolation rather than sampling variability in the underlying data. The genuine panel has four observations across two countries and two years, which leaves no degrees of freedom for a meaningful test. No significance claim is made in this draft. The earlier draft also described the close agreement between the reconstructed estimate and the companion paper’s \$114 million as “itself a form of validation”; since both derive from the same annual totals, and since \$114 million is the directly reported LVG figure rather than an independent estimate, that agreement was not evidence of anything and the claim is withdrawn.

Limitations. Two countries, two years, no pre-trend test. More fundamentally, the two series do not tax the same activity: Malaysia’s LVG regime is a sales tax on imported physical goods below RM500, while Vietnam’s foreign-supplier portal collects VAT and corporate income tax on nonresident digital services. Vietnam’s suitability as a control therefore rests on the absence of a change to its own base over the period, not on the two bases being comparable, and the comparison should be read as bounding rather than identifying the effect. A synthetic control across more ASEAN comparators, a placebo-date test, or a control series drawn from a goods-import regime would each materially strengthen this and are noted as future work in both papers.

7. Regional calibration

Table 7. ASEAN-5 calibration, 2024

Country	Digital GMV	Platform revenue	Unbooked GTV	Ratio
Indonesia	\$71.0B	\$4.18B	\$66.8B	16.0×
Vietnam	\$32.0B	\$1.88B	\$30.1B	16.0×
Philippines	\$38.0B	\$2.23B	\$35.8B	16.0×
Thailand	\$24.0B	\$1.41B	\$22.6B	16.0×
Malaysia	\$16.0B	\$0.94B	\$15.1B	16.0×
ASEAN-5	\$181B	\$10.64B	\$170B	16.0×

The four non-Indonesian rows apply the same 5.88% retained share. Their identical ratios are arithmetic, not an empirical cross-country regularity.

Four of these five country figures — Vietnam, Philippines, Thailand, and Malaysia — apply the same 5.88% blended take rate measured from Indonesia to each country’s own GMV. They are calibrated rescalings, not independent country-level measurements. Every row is therefore exactly 16.0× by construction: the ratio is a deterministic function of the single assumed take rate, and the apparent agreement across countries is arithmetic rather than an empirical finding. Only Indonesia is grounded in platform-level financial data, and only Malaysia has an independent policy check (Section 6). The regional dollar total should be read as an order-of-magnitude estimate anchored on one directly measured country.

7.1 Cross-check against published tax collections

If the wedge estimates are roughly right, then observed digital tax collections should represent a small single-digit percentage of them. Table 8 reports that comparison for the three countries with published collection figures.

Table 8. Published collections relative to the calibrated wedge

Country	Unbooked GTV	Tax revenue	Effective rate
Indonesia	\$66.8B	\$0.825B	1.23%
Malaysia	\$15.1B	\$0.503B	3.34%
Vietnam	\$30.1B	\$0.376B	1.25%

These are descriptive ratios across differently defined tax bases; they are not validation tests of the full regional estimate.

8. Scope, interpretation, and limitations

8.1 GTV is not value-added or tax due

The wedge is gross transaction value not booked as platform revenue. It can include participant receipts, cost of goods, vehicle or labour costs, taxes already paid, refunds, and pass-through amounts. The paper therefore should not convert the full wedge into “untaxed value creation” without participant-level cost and filing data. A value-added share can be explored in sensitivity analysis, but it cannot be treated as measured by the current filings.

8.2 What remains outside the estimate

The estimates cover selected transaction platforms and omit many forms of digital labour, creator income, direct social-commerce transactions, and activity on smaller platforms. No separate creator-economy range is added because a source of comparable provenance has not been identified. This omission means the paper is incomplete as a census of platform income, but it also avoids adding a weakly sourced number to a calculation already dependent on calibration.

8.3 Data-provenance risk in the regional total

The Malaysia and Philippines GMV inputs differ from the January 2026 SSRN version. Each change should be tied to a dated, citable source before external submission. Until that documentation is supplied, Table 7 is

best read as an illustrative regional calibration and the empirical weight of the paper should rest on Indonesia, especially GoTo.

9. Policy implications: reporting first, liability second

The evidence supports a distinction between information collection and tax liability. OECD platform-reporting work and the European Union's DAC7 regime show that platforms can be required to identify sellers, collect transaction information, and report income-relevant data to tax authorities (OECD 2019, 2020a; European Union 2021). Those reporting duties do not imply that every gross payout should be taxed or withheld at the same rate. They create an auditable record from which thresholds, expenses, residence, and existing obligations can be determined.

For low-income or subsistence participants, an initial zero-liability registration channel could improve administrative visibility without immediately imposing a payment obligation. This is a design hypothesis, not a result established by the current data. Experiments in Sri Lanka and Benin show that formalisation is costly, take-up is limited without substantial incentives, and benefits are heterogeneous (de Mel, McKenzie and Woodruff 2013; Benhassine et al. 2018). Any zero-rated registration proposal should therefore be tested against participation, compliance costs, access to benefits, and the risk of driving activity away from formal platforms.

For participants above a clearly defined threshold, the strongest evidence supports platform-level information reporting. Withholding may be appropriate where the tax base is simple and deductible costs can be handled, but it is not automatically superior in every platform vertical. The platform already computes payouts and maintains identity and transaction records, which lowers reporting cost; whether it should also remit tax depends on local law, participant expenses, and administrative capacity (Kleven, Kreiner and Saez 2016; Slemrod 2019). The policy sequence implied by the paper is therefore: create reliable reporting, distinguish participant types, then evaluate withholding rather than treating it as the default consequence of visibility.

The ratio evidence measures the scale of the administrative problem. It does not determine the correct threshold, rate, deduction rule, or social-protection design. Those parameters require participant-level microdata and policy pilots.

10. Conclusion

This paper estimates a large gap between platform-mediated transaction value and the revenue booked by the platforms that coordinate it. Indonesia's three-platform estimate is \$66.8 billion, while a four-country calibration produces an ASEAN-5 total of \$170 billion and an ecosystem ratio of 16.0×. The calculation is most credible as an order-of-magnitude measure of recorded participant-facing transaction value outside routine third-party reporting. It is not a direct measure of profit, unpaid tax, or value-added.

The result that carries the greatest empirical weight is GoTo's Indonesia-native time series: the share of GTV not booked as revenue rises from 95.7 percent to 97.6 percent between 2020 and 2023. Malaysia's policy expansion provides a limited descriptive check, but the unmatched tax bases and four-observation panel rule out a causal interpretation. The regional calibration remains dependent on country-volume provenance, particularly for Malaysia and the Philippines.

The policy implication is consequently modest but actionable. Platforms already generate the information that modern tax systems normally obtain from fiscal intermediaries. Reporting rules can convert that private record into administrative visibility. Liability, withholding, deductions, and formalisation benefits should then be designed separately rather than inferred from gross transaction value.

Appendix A. Correction and provenance history

This paper has been revised three times. Each round is recorded here so that the body of the paper can be read as an argument rather than as an errata list.

First round: sourcing. An earlier version cited two of three Indonesia platform figures to SEC filings that do not contain those figures at the country level. Grab’s Indonesia revenue is \$605 million as directly disclosed in its 20-F, not the \$1.2 billion previously reported; Sea Limited’s 20-F does not disclose an Indonesia-specific figure for Shopee at all, only a combined Southeast Asia total. Both are now labelled by provenance in Table 2.

Second round: ratio definition and inference. The ecosystem ratio was reported throughout as $\text{GTV} \div \text{Revenue}$ while being defined as $(\text{GTV} - \text{Revenue}) \div \text{Revenue}$. The underlying data files compute it correctly under the stated definition; the error was introduced in the paper’s tables. Every ratio is accordingly reduced by exactly one: $17.0\times$ becomes $16.0\times$ for both Indonesia and the ASEAN-5. Dollar magnitudes are unaffected, since the wedge itself was always computed as $\text{GTV} - \text{Revenue}$. Separately, the Malaysia difference-in-differences estimate was previously derived from an interpolated quarterly panel and reported with a p-value below .001; that claim is withdrawn, for the reasons given in Section 6.

Third round: provenance and figure values. The introduction’s opening figure for Southeast Asia’s 2024 platform-economy size was reported as \$200 billion; the figure in the cited report (Google, Temasek and Bain 2024) is \$263 billion, which is also the figure the January 2026 SSRN posting used. The error was introduced during revision and is now reverted. Separately, Figure 2’s “original draft” bars previously showed \$225 billion and $12.4\times$, values matching no version of this paper; the SSRN posting reports \$192 billion and $12.3\times$, and the figure now shows those.

Fourth item: residual rounding. The Indonesia and ASEAN-5 ratios were reported as $15.9\times$ and $16.1\times$ respectively while the four calibrated countries were reported at exactly $16.0\times$. Since all five rows are generated by one take rate, they cannot differ; the spread arose from rounding revenue to one decimal place. All ratios are calculated from unrounded source values; displayed components may differ slightly because of rounding.

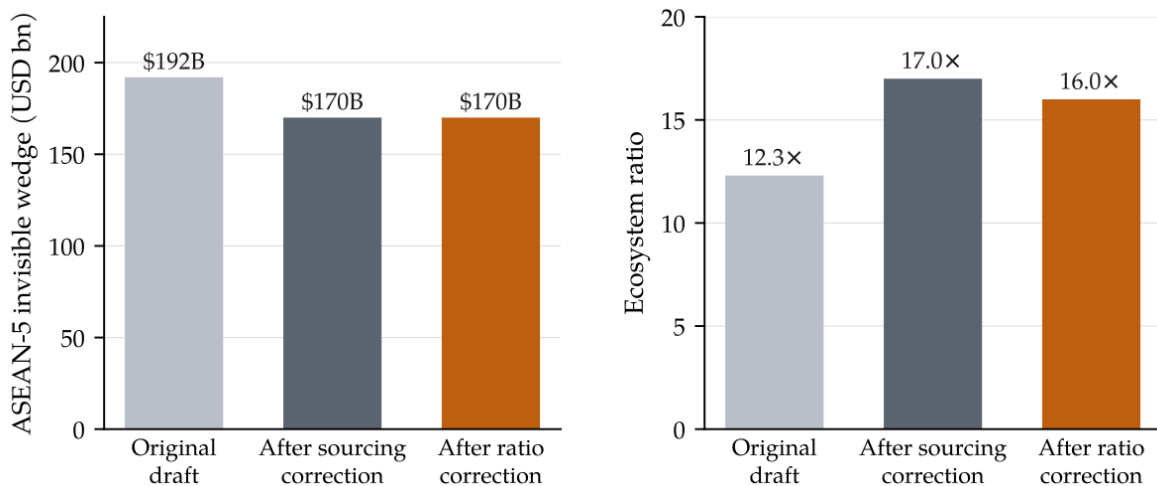


Figure 2. Correction history for the two headline numbers. The sourcing correction changed the dollar total; the ratio-definition correction changed the ratio without changing the wedge.

Data statement

The SEC filing figures were pulled from data.sec.gov (CIK 1855612 for Grab Holdings; CIK 1703399 for Sea Limited). GoTo figures are taken from its Indonesia Stock Exchange annual report. Malaysian and Vietnamese collection figures are annual totals from parliamentary and tax-authority reporting, with the period-average USD/MYR and USD/VND conventions stated in Section 6. Code and source-lineage files are available from the author upon request.

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